This increased engagement underscores the effectiveness of populist-style rhetoric in connecting with audiences. Likes and retweets are widely regarded as key indicators of public approval and responsiveness on social media (Schöll, Gallego, and Le Mens 2024). Our findings suggest that the public reacts more positively to communication strategies emphasizing relatable, people-centered messaging.

We further examine whether the impact of populist-style rhetoric on engagement is amplified during periods of heightened global populism. Incorporating a dummy variable to denote the populist surge that manifested during 2015–2019 (Kyle and Meyer 2020), we assess its moderating effect. Figure 7.2 illustrates the estimated marginal effects of populist-style tweets during this period. During the populist surge, people-centric tweets experienced a 12 percent increase in likes and a 13 percent rise in retweets compared with other tweets. These findings align with our expectations, highlighting the heightened receptivity of audiences to populist-style rhetoric during periods of global populist leadership and discourse.

To ensure the robustness of our results, we performed several additional tests. First, to address concerns that differences in public engagement might arise from the tweet's topic rather than from its populist style, we used a Structural Topic Model (Roberts et al. 2013) to assign topics to tweets (we tuned the model to 15 topics). Even after controlling for the tweet's topic, populist-style tweets retained significantly higher engagement levels (columns 5–6, table 7.2). Next, to investigate whether engagement was driven by elite users, we analyzed a random sample of 10,000 tweets and classified retweeters as "elite" if they had a verified account or at least 1,000 followers. Results in table 7.3 show no significant difference in elite engagement with populist-style tweets, indicating that such tweets resonate broadly with general audiences, not elites.

These findings reveal that IOs can significantly increase public engagement by employing populist-style rhetoric, particularly during periods of heightened populist sentiment. This suggests that IOs' strategic use of relatable, people-focused messaging is received warmly by diverse audiences, extending beyond the traditional elite populations often associated with IOs.